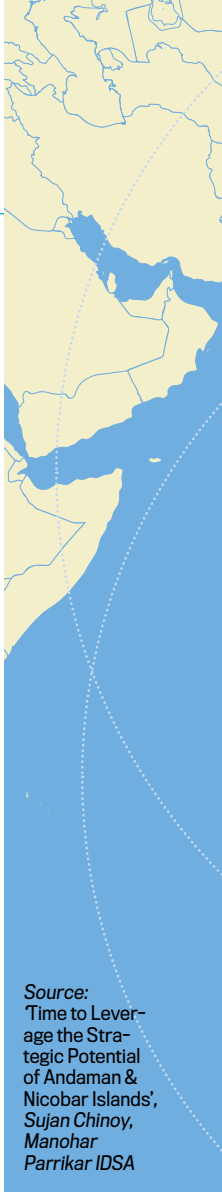
NEGLECTED BASTIONS

CAN THE ANDAMAN & NICOBAR ISLANDS BECOME THE FOCUS OF INDIA'S MILITARY STRATEGY AGAINST A BELLIGERENT CHINA? THERE IS PLENTY OF INTENT, BUT INSUFFICIENT MILITARY CAPACITY ON THE GROUND

By Sandeep Unnithan



Source: 'Time to Leverage the Strategic Potential of Andaman & Nicobar Islands', *Sujan Chinoy, Manohar Parrikar IDSA*

FROM HIGH ABOVE, Teressa Island resembles a giant green boomerang, frozen mid-throw over an azure sea. Last December, this island in the Nicobar chain was a military objective for over 100 soldiers from an elite army unit. Leaping out of the back of a C-130J transport, paratroopers from the Agra-based Shatrujeet Brigade practised parachuting onto the island and securing a drop zone, simulating how India would react to an invasion of the islands. In a real-world scenario, it would be the entire 3,000-man brigade parachuting and airlanding to capture key installations like airfields before a larger friendly seaborne force arrived. The brigade's emblem, a winged centaur drawing a bow, symbolises its composite capabilities. It has seen action in all of independent India's conflicts—two successes in the modern era involved an operation behind enemy lines in erstwhile East Pakistan in 1971 and thwarting a coup in the Maldives in 1989.

The last time the Andaman & Nicobar (A&N) Islands were invaded was 80 years ago, in 1942, when the Imperial Japanese Navy—then the most powerful naval force in Asia—drove out the British and occupied the archipelago. In recent years, the PLAN (People's Liberation Army Navy) has mimicked the rise of the Japanese navy, growing at an astonishing speed. In 2021, it added more submarines, destroyers and amphibious assault ships to its fleet than all the warships in the Vizag-based Eastern Naval Command. This means it can continue to deploy an increasing number of warships in the Indian Ocean region, as it has done over the past decade. It also has bases in Gwadar in Pakistan and Djibouti on the horn of Africa. A strong naval force helps China project power and overcome what is called 'Beijing's Malacca dilemma'—of 65 per cent of its oil imports transiting through the narrow Malacca Straits.

China's rise, and this possible maritime vulnerability, have prompted New Delhi to look more closely at the